



India's most hyped cricket tournament, the IPL, begins with a record-busting opening and high TV ratings—but it has many promises to keep

FEVER

■ By Sharda Ugra

It was a sight guaranteed to make Lalit Modi and Shah Rukh Khan burst into a duet, no trees required. Shortly before the opening of the Indian Premier League (IPL), two men marched up Bangalore's Bridge Road carrying a handmade poster with the sketch of a golden helmet and the words "Knight Riders" scrawled on it in English and Bengali.

In Modi's fantasy world of radically recast cricket loyalties, the men wouldn't have made it to the top of the road, set upon by rival supporters of the Royal Challengers, Bangalore, whom the Knight Riders were meeting that evening. The men, though, moved freely toward the impossibly extravagant opening ceremony (rumoured cost Rs 6 crore) and within hours, the IPL a non-stop 24/7 assault on the senses—and on sensibilities—was upon us.

Whether it was the novelty of seeing Washington Redskins cheer leaders attempt to groove to a Kannada song from the Rajkumar hit *Akasmika*



MATES: India's Karthik and Australia's Ponting celebrate a Kolkata Knight Riders moment

SUBIR HALDAR